ELIMINATION PLAYS

ABOUT THE DEALS

Feel free to disagree with the bidding; remember that it is only there so as to get to a contract appropriate for some particular elimination play. In fact, the bidding is irrelevant except in Deals where the opponent's bids may influence your actions.

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. This is to get you started thinking about how you would play the hand.

There are four or five stages shown for each Deal.

You are always going to be the Declarer, playing in the South position.

ELIMINATION PLAYS SUMMARY

There are a lot of card combinations in Bridge in which you will be better off if the opponents make the first play in a suit than you would be if you must play it first. Here are three examples.

♦ K 10 3	♦ J 7 3	♦ K 10 3
♦ A J 7	♦ Q 5 2	♦ A 9 7

The first is the frequently occurring two-way finesse. If you play this yourself you have to guess which defender holds the Queen. If the defenders start the suit you automatically win all three tricks.

In the second example you'd like to win one trick, and it will be hard to do if you must start the suit. Perhaps one defender holds both the high honors and you can guess which one and lead through him. Or perhaps someone has a doubleton honor that you can deduce. But if the defenders break the suit you just play second-hand-low and can't miss winning one trick.

With the third example you have almost no chance of three tricks if you start. If they start the suit you play second-hand-low and the next defender must play an honor. You win and then finesse the other defender for the other honor, winning all three tricks when their two honors are divided.

These are only three of many combinations that will benefit you if you can force the defenders to start the suit.
And that is what Elimination plays do; force the defenders to play a particular suit for you.

It works like this. You **strip** the defenders of all their "safe" exit suits, then you **throw-in** one of the defenders. If he has no safe exit, he will have to play a suit that will benefit you, perhaps one of the combinations above.

You will find that most elimination plays occur in suit contracts. This is because you can often pull all the defender's trumps while retaining at least one in both your hand and dummy. Then when the throw-in occurs the defense cannot play a suit of which you and dummy are both void because of the threat of a ruff and sluff.

25 examples are probably worth more than 1000 words.

Deal 1 Ctr: **4♥** Goal: at most ____ losers



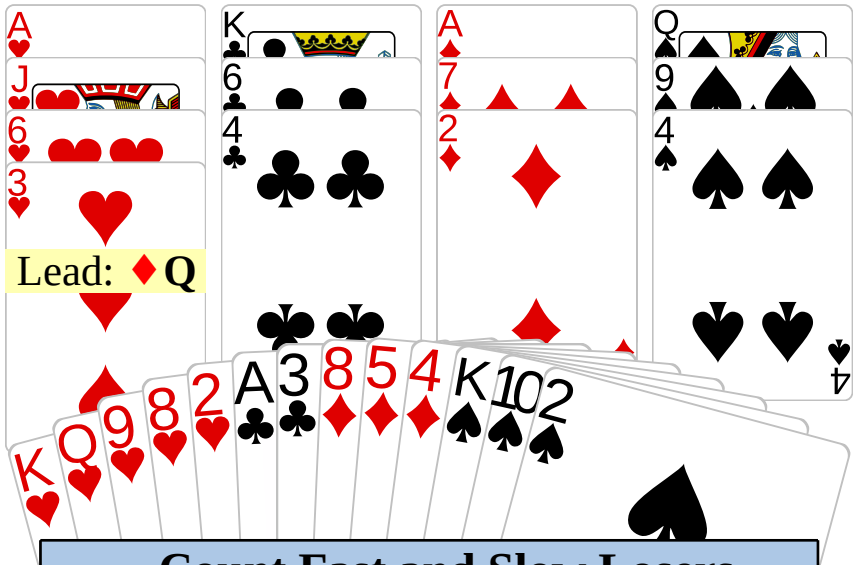
Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 2 Ctr: **6♦** Goal: at most ____ losers



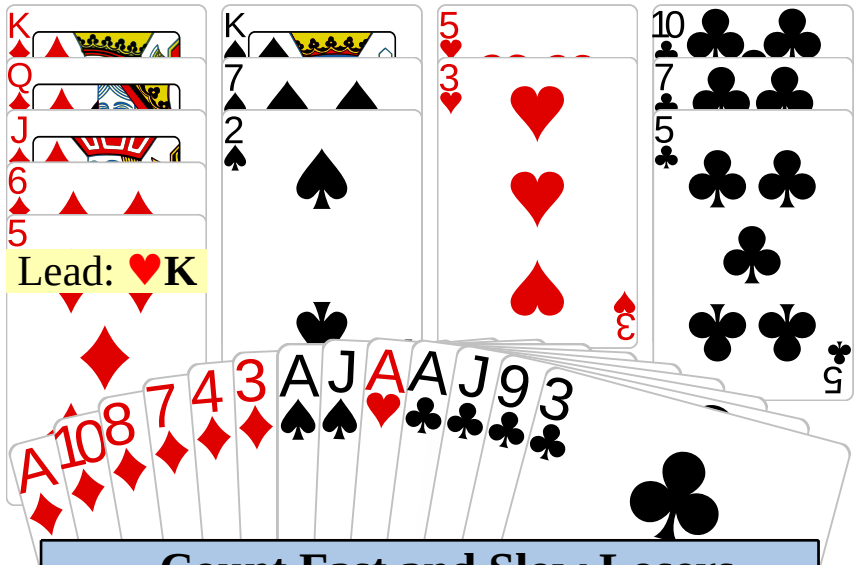
Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 3 Ctr: **4♥** Goal: at most ____ losers



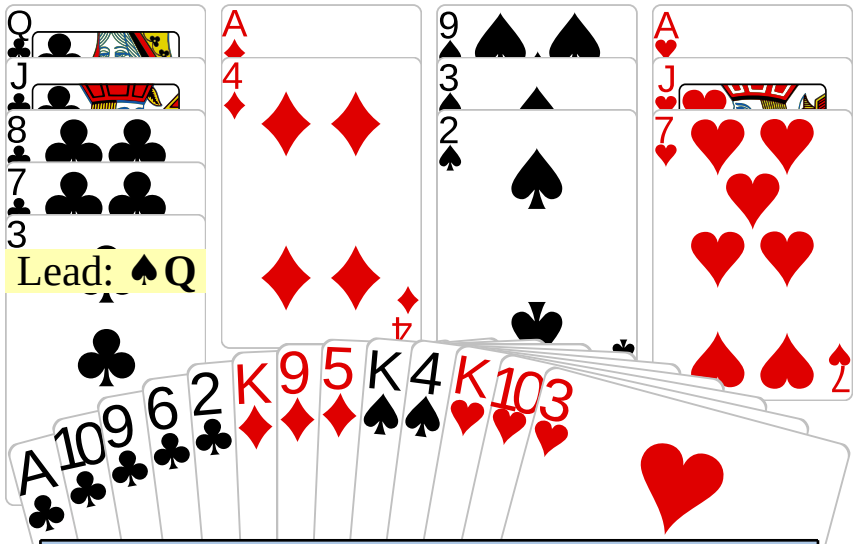
Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 4 Ctr: **6♦** Goal: at most ____ losers



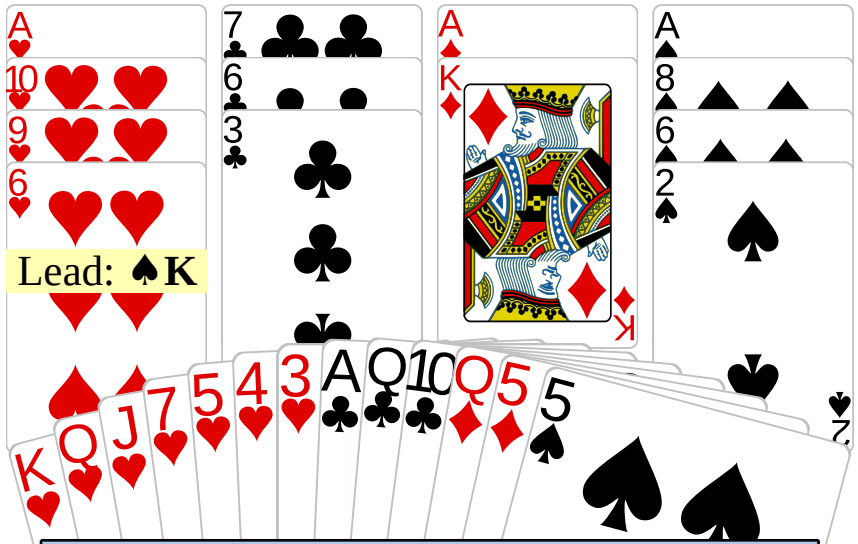
Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 5 Ctr: **5♣** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 6 Ctr: **6♥** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: North
Lead: ♠K

Board: 2
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 6♦
Declarer: East
Lead: ♠Q

Board: 3
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: South
Lead: ♦Q

Board: 4
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 6♦
Declarer: West
Lead: ♥K

Board: 5
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 5♣
Declarer: North
Lead: ♠Q

Board: 6
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 6♥
Declarer: East
Lead: ♠K

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ J 10 5 ♥ A J 6 4 ♦ A J 7 ♣ A J 4	
♠ A 7 6 ♥ 9 7 3 ♦ 10 6 4 3 ♣ Q 8 7	N W E S	♠ K Q 9 4 2 ♥ 5 ♦ Q 8 2 ♣ 9 6 5 3
	♠ 8 3 ♥ K Q 10 8 2 ♦ K 9 5 ♣ K 10 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	2♦
Pass	2♥	Pass	3NT
Pass	4♥		
All Pass			

4♥ by North
Lead: ♠K

South first transfers you to ♥s, then gives you a choice of which game to play. Knowing you have an 9-card trump fit, you choose 4♥.

North is to play 4♥. The defenders start with ♠K, ♠Q, ♠A.

In addition to the two ♠s already lost you have a potential loser in each minor suit. On the plus side, you have a finesse position in ♦s and a two-way finesse in ♣s. If you work both finesses successfully you make an overtrick - if both fail you will be down 1. Or, you could try for a 100% sure end-play.

Ruff the ♠A with dummy's ♥10 and pull trumps (three rounds).

You cash the ♦K and ♦A.

You eliminate ♦s with the ♦K, ♦A and ♦J. If you are REALLY lucky the ♦Q will fall doubleton, but more than likely a defender will win the third ♦. He won't be happy about it, though.

Whichever defender wins the ♦Q is end-played. If he plays a ♦ or a ♠ you will ruff in one hand and discard a ♣ loser from the other. But if he leads a ♣ instead you no longer have a ♣ loser.

On this Deal an elimination play will guarantee that you make your contract.

However, it also guarantees that you will not make an overtrick.

If you try the two finesses instead you **MIGHT** make an overtrick, but you also might go down 1.

Decide for yourself!

Board 2
West Deals
N-S Vul

♠ K 9 7 4
♥ 10 9 5 4
♦ 8 2
♣ K 10 2

♠ A
♥ A K 6
♦ A K Q 9 7 4
♣ A Q 9



♠ 8 6 2
♥ J 3
♦ J 10 6 5
♣ 7 6 4 3

♠ Q J 10 5 3
♥ Q 8 7 2
♦ 3
♣ J 8 5

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
2♣	Pass	2♦	Pass
3♦	Pass	4♦	Pass
6♦			
All Pass			

6♦ by East
Lead: ♠Q

You naturally respond 2♦ to West's strong 2♣ opener. Before you know it you are playing a slam - with your mighty 2-point hand! East plays 6♦. South leads the ♠Q.

If the contract appears to depend upon a finesse, try to find another way. Here, you can always try the ♣ finesse, but maybe you can eliminate ♠s and see what happens.

Win the ♠A, play the ♦4 to the ♦10, and ruff a ♠ with the ♦Q. Both opponents followed to the trump.

Play the ♦7 to the ♦J and ruff the last ♠ with the ♦K.

Having eliminated the ♦s and ♠s, now remove the ♥s. Play ♥A, ♥K, and ruff a ♥.

At last it is time to play ♣s.

South plays low.

A ♣ from your hand, playing dummy's ♣9 when South plays low. North will win the trick but will be end-played, forced to either play a ♣ back to dummy's ♣ A Q, or give you a ruff-sluff.

If South puts on either the ♣10 or ♣J you play dummy's ♣Q. If North can win with the ♣K he will once again be end-played, forced to either play a ♣ back to dummy's ♣A 9, or give you a ruff-sluff.

The A Q 9 combination is interesting. Obviously if you have A Q 10 it works very well in an end-play situation.

As you see, A Q 9 actually works just as well.

Board 3
North Deals
None Vul

♠ Q 9 4
♥ A J 6 3
♦ A 7 2
♣ K 6 4

♠ A 8 6 3
♥ 7
♦ Q J 10 6
♣ J 10 7 2



♠ J 7 5
♥ 10 5 4
♦ K 9 3
♣ Q 9 8 5

♠ K 10 2
♥ K Q 9 8 2
♦ 8 5 4
♣ A 3

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♣	Pass	1♥
Pass	2♥	Pass	4♥
All Pass			

4♥ by South
Lead: ♦Q

South is to play 4♥. West leads the ♦Q.

You have two ♦ losers that you can't escape, as well as the ♠A. So you must arrange your play so you don't lose a trick to the ♠J. That could mean you will finesse one defender for that card, but it would be a lot better if you could make the defense play ♠s first.

There is no reason to hold up so take your ♦A and pull trumps, East showing up with three of them.

Now eliminate ♣s by playing ♣A, ♣K, and ruffing a ♣.

The stage is now set for the throw-in.

Be **SURE** to lead a ♦ for the throw-in, not a ♠.

The defense will win the ♦ and can then take another ♦ trick if they like. But then they will have to play a ♠ (or give you a ruff-sluff). And as long as they start the ♠s you are assured that you will lose only one ♠ trick, the ♠A.

Assume West is on lead for the first ♠ play.

If he leads the ♠A it sets up both the ♠K and ♠Q so you only have one ♠ loser. If he leads low you also play low from dummy and East must play the ♠J to prevent you getting a trick with the ♠10. Again you only lose one ♠.

If East makes the first play by leading a low ♠ you play low from your hand. West must go up with the ♠A to stop you from getting a trick with dummy's ♠9. Then your ♠K and ♠Q will win two tricks.

Board 4
South Deals
Both Vul

♠ 10 8 5
♥ K Q J 10 8 4
♦ —
♣ K Q 4 2

♠ A J
♥ A
♦ A 10 8 7 4 3
♣ A J 9 3



♠ K 7 2
♥ 5 3
♦ K Q J 6 5
♣ 10 7 5

♠ Q 9 6 4 3
♥ 9 7 6 2
♦ 9 2
♣ 8 6

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			Pass
1♦	1♥	2♥	Dbl
6♦			
All Pass			

6♦ by West
Lead: ♥K

East's 2♥ bid showed a hand with limit raise or better in ♦s. West doesn't bother with Blackwood since he already knows about the Aces. He just bids the slam. West plays 6♦. North leads the ♥K, won by you with the ♥A.

The good news is that you have no losers in ♠s, ♥, or ♦s. The bad news is that you have two losers in ♣s. The good news is that missing the ♣ K Q you could try two finesses. The bad news is that North overcalled, so he probably has both honors. The best news of all is that you know how to pull off an elimination play!. Play a trump to dummy's ♦K (North discards a ♥) and ruff the ♥5.

Pull the outstanding trump with the ♦A, then play ♠A, ♠K and ruff a ♠.

You want to play the first ♣ from dummy.

You enter dummy with a trump.

Dummy leads the ♣10 and South plays low.

Play the ♣10 from dummy and let it ride if South does not produce the ♣Q or ♣K. North will win with one of the honors but will have to return another ♣ or give you a ruff-sluff.

When you are missing the K Q of a suit, as in the ♣s on this hand, taking two finesses gives you a 75% chance of success - **all things being equal**.

In this case though, North's overcall means all things are not equal, so your chances are lower than 75%.

But never mind the percentages for a finesse, the end-play was a sure thing.

Board 5
North Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ K 4 ♥ K 10 3 ♦ K 9 5 ♣ A 10 9 6 2	
♠ A 6 5 ♥ Q 9 8 2 ♦ 10 8 7 6 2 ♣ 5	N W E S	♠ Q J 10 8 7 ♥ 6 5 4 ♦ Q J 3 ♣ K 4
	♠ 9 3 2 ♥ A J 7 ♦ A 4 ♣ Q J 8 7 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♣	1♠	2♠
Pass	3♣	Pass	5♣
All Pass			

5♣ by North
Lead: ♠Q

South's cue-bid shows a limit raise or better (11 points) in ♣s. North is to play 5♣. East leads the ♠Q, West takes the ♠A and returns the ♠6 to your ♠K.

You have lost one trick already and have a possible loser in trumps and another possible loser in ♥s. Both loserscan be avoided with successful finesses. The problem with the ♣ finesse is that East made an overcall so he is more likely to hold the ♣K. If you don't try the ♣ finesse you may be able to throw a defender in with the ♣K at a time when he will have to help you with his next play.

After winning the ♠K immediately play the ♣A.

It would have been nice to see the ♣K fall, but it didn't. So play a small ♦ to dummy's ♦A and play the ♠9, ruffing in your hand.

Eliminate the ♦s by playing ♦K, then ruffing your last ♦ in dummy.

You have done all the eliminating, time to throw in somebody.

You play a ♣ to throw East in.

Whichever defender had the ♣K is now on lead, but wishes he wasn't. If he plays a ♥ you get a free finesse. If he plays anything else you get a ruff-sluff.

If you had finessed for the ♣K East would have won the trick and been able to make a safe exit, probably with his other ♣.

You would then have been forced to rely on the ♥ finesse, and with East being the defender who showed some strength, you would likely have finessed through him.

About the only way the elimination/throw-in could fail is if the ♣s split 3-0. Then, if you play Ace and another the defender who wins would use his third ♣ as a safe exit.

Board 6
South Deals
E-W Vul

♠ J 9 7 4
♥ 8
♦ J 9 6 4 3
♣ 9 8 2

♠ A 8 6 2
♥ A 10 9 6
♦ A K
♣ 7 6 3



♠ 5
♥ K Q J 7 5 4 3
♦ Q 5
♣ A Q 10

♠ K Q 10 3
♥ 2
♦ 10 8 7 2
♣ K J 5 4

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			Pass
1NT	Pass	3♥	Pass
4♥	Pass	5♣	Pass
6♥			
All Pass			

6♥ by East
Lead: ♠K

Your 3♥ bid is a slam suggestion. After you show the ♣A partner wastes no time in bidding it.

East is to play 6♥. South leads the ♠K.

This is a good slam. You have only two possible ♣ losers, and by taking two ♣ finesses you have an excellent chance of success. But by using an elimination play you will have a sure thing.

Win the ♠A and ruff a ♠ with a ♥ honor.

Play a small ♥ to dummy's ♥9 and ruff another ♠. Both defenders followed to the trump play.

Play another ♥ to dummy's ♥10 and ruff the last ♠.

Play the ♦A and ♦K.

Conveniently you are in dummy.

North plays low.

You play a ♣ from dummy and insert the ♣10 when North plays low.

South will probably win this trick. If he wins with the ♣K then your hand is good. If he wins with the ♣J then he is end-played, forced to either lead a ♣ into your ♣ A Q or to give you a ruff-sluff.

You probably noticed that you could have finessed your ♣Q on the first ♣ play and pulled off the end-play just as effectively. But there is an advantage to making the first finesse with the ♣10.

If North just happens to hold both the ♣K and ♣J you will make all thirteen tricks if your first finesse is with the ♣10!